Hints: Limits – 3. Asymptotics of sequences

Homework

The hints to each problem are cumulative. Read one, try again, and open the next only if you are still stuck.

Problem 1

Hint 1. The map $g(x) = x - \arcsin(\sin^3 x)$ is odd, so it suffices to take $x_0 \in (0, 1]$ (for $x_0 = 0$ the sequence is 0). For $x \in (0, 1]$: $0 < \sin^3 x < \sin x$, so $0 < \arcsin(\sin^3 x) < x$; hence x_n stays in $(0, 1]$, decreases, and tends to a fixed point, i.e. to 0.

Hint 2. Here $\arcsin(\sin^3 x) = x^3 + O(x^5)$, so $x_{n+1} = x_n - x_n^3 + O(x_n^5)$: Theorem 1 with $p = 3$, $a = 1$. Telescoping: $\dfrac{1}{x_{n+1}^2} - \dfrac{1}{x_n^2} \to 2$, and Stolz gives $nx_n^2 \to \frac{1}{2}$.

Hint 3. Answer: $\lim \sqrt{n}\, x_n = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}$ for $x_0 \in (0, 1]$, $-\frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}$ for $x_0 \in [-1, 0)$, and 0 for $x_0 = 0$.

Problem 2

Hint 1. Substitute $t = nx$: $b_n = \frac{1}{n}\int_0^n f(t)\,dt = \frac{1}{n}\sum_{k=0}^{n-1} a_k$.

Hint 2. So b_n is the Cesàro mean of (a_k), and converges to the same limit (Stolz–Cesàro).

Problem 3

Hint 1. In vector form $v_{n+1} = v_n - \frac{1}{n}(Av_n - b)$ with $A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$ and $b = \begin{pmatrix} 4 \\ 3 \end{pmatrix}$. The only candidate for the limit is the solution of $Av = b$, namely $v^* = (1, 2)$.

Hint 2. The error $e_n = v_n - v^*$ satisfies $e_{n+1} = (I - \frac{1}{n}A)e_n$. The matrix A is symmetric with eigenvalues $\lambda_{1,2} = \frac{3 \pm \sqrt{5}}{2} > 0$; in an orthonormal eigenbasis the two coordinates evolve separately: $u_{n+1} = (1 - \frac{\lambda}{n})u_n$.

Hint 3. For $n > \lambda$ the factors are in $(0, 1)$ and $\prod_{k=N}^{n}(1 - \frac{\lambda}{k}) = \exp\bigl(-\lambda \ln n + O(1)\bigr) \asymp n^{-\lambda}$. So each coordinate is $O(n^{-\lambda})$, and the slower one gives $|v_n - v^*| = O\bigl(n^{-(3-\sqrt{5})/2}\bigr)$. Answer: the limit is $(1, 2)$.

Problem 4

Hint 1. The numerator is a geometric progression: $\frac{n^{n+1}-n}{n-1} \sim n^n$. Divide everything by n^n.

Hint 2. The denominator becomes $\sum_{j=0}^{n-1}(1 - \frac{j}{n})^n$. Each term tends to e^{-j} and is at most e^{-j} (since $1 - t \leqslant e^{-t}$), so the sum tends to $\sum_{j \geqslant 0} e^{-j} = \frac{e}{e-1}$ (cut the sum at a large fixed J; the tail is at most $\sum_{j>J} e^{-j}$).

Hint 3. Answer: $\dfrac{e-1}{e}$.

Problem 5

Hint 1. a) $g_n(x) = f(x) - x^n$ is strictly decreasing, $g_n(0) = f(0) > f(1) \geqslant 0$ and $g_n(1) = f(1) - 1 < f(0) - 1 \leqslant 0$: one root $a_n \in (0, 1)$. Since $g_{n+1}(a_n) = a_n^n - a_n^{n+1} > 0$, the sequence a_n increases. If $a_n \to L < 1$, then $a_n^n \to 0$ and $f(L) = 0$, but $f(1) < f(L)$ and $f(1) \geqslant 0$.

Hint 2. b) Put $t_n = 1 - a_n \to 0$ and $c = -f'(1) > 0$. Then $f(a_n) = ct_n(1 + o(1))$ and $a_n^n = e^{-nt_n(1+o(1))}$, so taking logarithms,

$$nt_n(1 + o(1)) = \ln \frac{1}{t_n} + O(1).$$

Deduce $t_n \sim \frac{\ln n}{n}$ (first show $\frac{1}{n} \lesssim t_n \lesssim n^{-1/2}$, so that $\ln \frac{1}{t_n} \sim \ln n$).

Hint 3. $F(a_n) = \int_{a_n}^1 f \sim \frac{c}{2} t_n^2 \sim \frac{c}{2}\Big(\frac{\ln n}{n}\Big)^2$. So $\sum F(a_n)^\alpha$ behaves like $\sum \big(\frac{\ln n}{n}\big)^{2\alpha}$: it converges exactly for $\alpha > \frac{1}{2}$ (for $\alpha \leqslant 0$ the terms do not even tend to 0).

Problem 6

Hint 1. Rewrite: $x_{n+2} - 2x_{n+1} = (x_{n+1} - 2x_n) + \frac{2^n}{x_n}$. So $d_n = x_{n+1} - 2x_n$ satisfies $d_1 = 0$, $d_{n+1} = d_n + \frac{2^n}{x_n}$.

Hint 2. Put $y_n = x_n/2^n$. Dividing by 2^{n+1}: $y_{n+1} - y_n = \frac{d_n}{2^{n+1}}$, and $\frac{2^n}{x_n} = \frac{1}{y_n}$, so $d_n = \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} \frac{1}{y_k}$. Hence $d_n \geqslant 0$, y_n is non-decreasing, $y_n \geqslant y_1 = 1$ and $d_n \leqslant n - 1$.

Hint 3. Then $0 \leqslant y_{n+1} - y_n \leqslant \frac{n-1}{2^{n+1}}$ is summable, so $L = \lim y_n$ exists and $L \leqslant 1 + \sum_{n\geqslant 1} \frac{n-1}{2^{n+1}} = \frac{3}{2}$. Using $y_k \leqslant \frac{3}{2}$ in d_n gives $L \geqslant 1 + \frac{2}{3} \cdot \frac{1}{2} = \frac{4}{3}$.

Hint 4. Iterating these bounds (compute the first few y_k exactly, estimate the tail) sharpens them; numerically $L \approx 1.4782$.

Problem 7

Hint 1. Near 0 the integrand is $\frac{nx}{\sin x} \leqslant \frac{\pi n}{2}$, so the integral converges. Split $\frac{1}{\sin x} = \frac{1}{x} + (\frac{1}{\sin x} - \frac{1}{x})$; the bracket is bounded on $(0, \frac{\pi}{2}]$, so that part of $I(n)$ is $O(1)$.

Hint 2. Substitute $t = nx$: $\displaystyle\int_0^{\pi/2} \frac{\{nx\}}{x}\, dx = \int_0^{n\pi/2} \frac{\{t\}}{t}\, dt = O(1) + \frac{1}{2}\ln n + \int_1^{n\pi/2} \frac{\{t\} - \frac{1}{2}}{t}\, dt.$

Hint 3. The last integral is bounded: $G(t) = \int_0^t (\{s\} - \frac{1}{2})ds$ is 1-periodic and bounded, and integration by parts gives $\int_1^T \frac{G'(t)}{t}\, dt = \frac{G(T)}{T} - G(1) + \int_1^T \frac{G(t)}{t^2}\, dt = O(1)$. Hence $I(n) = \frac{1}{2}\ln n + O(1)$, which gives both bounds and $\lim \frac{I(n)}{\ln n} = \frac{1}{2}$. (Alternatively, compute $\int_0^1 \frac{\{nx\}}{x}\, dx = n - (n-1)\ln n + \ln(n-1)!$ and apply Stolz.)

Problem 8

Hint 1. Invert: $\displaystyle\frac{1}{a_{n+1}} = \frac{1}{a_n} + 1 + a_n.$

Hint 2. Hence $\frac{1}{a_n} \geqslant \frac{1}{a_0} + n$, so $a_n \to 0$; then $\frac{1}{a_{n+1}} - \frac{1}{a_n} \to 1$ and Stolz gives $\lim n a_n = 1$.

Problem 9

Hint 1. Write $1 + x + \cdots + x^n = \frac{1-x^{n+1}}{1-x}$, so $\ln(1 + \cdots + x^n) = \ln(1 - x^{n+1}) - \ln(1 - x)$. Since $\int_0^1 \ln^2(1 - x)\, dx = 2$, you get, with $m = n + 1$,

$$2 - x_n = \int_0^1 \Big(-\ln(1 - x^m)\Big)\Big(-\ln(1 - x)\Big)dx \geqslant 0,$$

and the integrand is $O\big(\ln^2(1 - x)\big)$ near 1, so everything is finite.

Hint 2. Expand $-\ln(1 - x^m) = \sum_{k\geqslant 1} \frac{x^{mk}}{k}$ and use $\int_0^1 x^N\big(-\ln(1 - x)\big)dx = \frac{H_{N+1}}{N+1}$ (expand $-\ln(1 - x)$ as well). This gives

$$2 - x_n = \sum_{k\geqslant 1} \frac{H_{mk+1}}{k\,(mk + 1)}.$$

Hint 3. With $H_N = \ln N + O(1)$: $2 - x_n = \frac{1}{m}\sum_{k\geqslant 1}\frac{\ln m + \ln k + O(1)}{k^2} = \zeta(2)\frac{\ln m}{m} + O\big(\frac{1}{m}\big)$. In particular $x_n \to 2$, and $\lim \frac{n}{\ln n}(2 - x_n) = \zeta(2) = \frac{\pi^2}{6}$.

Problem 10

Hint 1. Write $\sqrt[n]{1+x^n} - 1 = e^u - 1$ with $u = \frac{\ln(1+x^n)}{n} \in [0, \frac{\ln 2}{n}]$. Since $u \leqslant e^u - 1 \leqslant u + u^2$ for small u and $u \leqslant \frac{x^n}{n}$, the quadratic part contributes at most $n^2 \int_0^1 \frac{x^{2n}}{n^2}dx = \frac{1}{2n+1} \to 0$.

Hint 2. So it suffices to find $\lim n\int_0^1 \ln(1+x^n)\,dx$. Substitute $x = t^{1/n}$: $n\int_0^1 \ln(1+x^n)\,dx = \int_0^1 \frac{\ln(1+t)}{t}\,t^{1/n}\,dt$.

Hint 3. As $n \to \infty$ this tends to $\int_0^1 \frac{\ln(1+t)}{t}\,dt$ (the integrand increases to the limit). Expanding $\ln(1+t)$, the integral equals $\sum_{k\geqslant 1}\frac{(-1)^{k+1}}{k^2} = \frac{\pi^2}{12}$.